

The Reformation

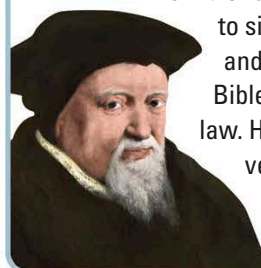
In 1517, Martin Luther wrote his *Ninety-Five Theses*—a list of complaints against the Catholic Church—and sent them to the Archbishop of Mainz. Luther was a German monk and professor of theology, and his act of protest launched the Reformation, a movement of religious change that permanently divided Christianity in Europe.

In the early 1500s, the Catholic Church was the only branch of Christianity in western Europe, as it had been for 1,000 years. At its head was the Pope in Rome, and under him were bishops, priests, and monks. The Church had religious power over all men and women, from kings to peasants. Some people, however, were beginning to challenge the Church's authority. They accused the Pope and other Church leaders of greed and questioned their right to

decide how people worshipped God. Printed copies of the *Theses* spread quickly across Europe, winning widespread support. As the Reformation grew, the Church split in two, with Catholics on one side and the reformers, who called themselves Protestants, on the other. Religious differences divided the Protestants, too. For more than 100 years, a series of devastating religious wars raged through much of Europe.

ULRICH ZWINGLI

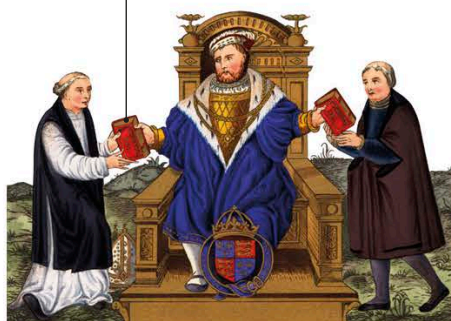
Ulrich Zwingli (1484–1531) was the leader of the Reformation in Switzerland. He wanted to simplify worship and taught that the Bible was God's law. His ideas were very influential.



◀ SELLING INDULGENCES

In his *Theses*, Martin Luther accused the Church of abusing the practice of selling “indulgences,” certificates that were supposed to reduce punishment for sins in the afterlife. Luther is said to have nailed the *Theses* to a church door in Wittenberg, Germany.

King Henry VIII hands out copies of his authorized version of the Bible in English.



▲ TRANSLATING THE BIBLE

The early reformers translated the Bible—believed to be the direct word of God—from Latin into the common European languages to make it available to all. A copy of an English translation of the Bible was placed in every church in England.

